



GOVERNANCE

PRESSURE GROUPS

MODULE - 16

INTRODUCTION

- 1 Pressure groups can be considered as both 'influence groups' and particular 'interest groups'.
- 2 Unlike the political parties they do not put up the candidates for the election and therefore, are not completely a political organization.
- 3 These groups can also be termed as 'private institutions' formed to influence the policies of the government.



PRESSURE GROUPS: MEANING AND DEFINITIONS

- 1 These pressure groups are free and independent institutions and they serve important political ends.
- 2 Such interest groups which are organized for political action are also considered as pressure groups and such groups have direct political significance.
- 3 Thus, the prime function of a pressure group is to promote the interests of its members and pressurize the government.
- 4 They are concerned with specific issues and self-interest to promote their own cause is the basic reason of their formation and existence. They are non-political entities.



PRESSURE GROUPS: MEANING AND DEFINITIONS

- 5 They are involved in the political process but are not willing to assist in forming a government if called upon to do so.
- 6 They have no political programme or scheme as such.
- 7 They are the medium through which the function of articulation of interests is performed in a political system.



DIFFERENCE BETWEEN POLITICAL PARTY AND PRESSURE GROUPS

S.NO.	POLITICAL PARTY	PRESSURE GROUP
1	Political parties act directly and intervene in the policy matters, they are also legally entitled to frame policies concerning the Government.	The action of the pressure group is both indirect as well as intermittent. They indirectly influence and pressurise the government in order to get their interest and demand fulfilled.
2	Political parties work for national interest and they have permanent existence and works continuously for the longer needs of the public.	Pressure groups generally, for self-interest and they emerge and dissolve as per the need.
3	Political parties try to bring coordination in the working between the executive and legislature.	The pressure groups generally pressurise the executive and the legislature to fulfil the demand.

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN POLITICAL PARTY AND PRESSURE GROUPS

S.NO.	POLITICAL PARTY	PRESSURE GROUP
4	Political parties form and the constitute government.	Pressure groups is a public body that acts behind the Government (outside the political party).
5	Political parties generally use the constitutional means to execute its duties and functions.	Pressure groups uses both conventional and non-conventional means to put forth their demands.
6	Political parties are recognised by the Election Commission.	Pressure groups are temporary as they emerge and dissolve.

MEDIA AS PRESSURE GROUP

1 The media plays an important role in displaying various happenings of the politics and life of common people.

2 In countries such as in India the mass media such as the radio, TV, cinema and the press are very powerful mediums of social change and also act as pressure groups for representing the interests of the common man and exposes all the deeds of the government.

3 Media can work without restriction and expose the functioning of the government and have no such restriction.



MEDIA AS PRESSURE GROUP

4 Moreover, the mass media help to set-up a common platform which try to focus on the core issues of the society.

5 Hence, role of the media is much more important in influencing the functioning of the political parties than that of other such pressure groups.

6 Therefore, in the contemporary world the media acts as an agent of social change, focusing on the social development of the society.

7 Media also pressurizes the government which is also of significant importance.



MAJOR PRESSURE GROUPS IN INDIA

Some of the major pressure groups in India are as follows:

a. PEASANT ORGANIZATIONS

These organizations gained power during the 1960s, at the national level All India Kisan Congress plays a dominant role, whereas in state level number of organizations exists namely Akhil Bhartiya Kisan Sangh, Farmers Collective, Bhartiya Kisan Party, etc.



भारतीय किसान संघ
BHARATIYA KISAN SANGH
A non-political organization of the farmers, for the farmers, by the farmers



b. LINGUISTIC GROUPS

These are pressure groups formed to promote and endorse certain languages. Some of the organizations are, Hindi Parishad, Tamil Sangh, Telugu Sangh, Punjabi Sahit Sabhas, etc.



MAJOR PRESSURE GROUPS IN INDIA

Some of the major pressure groups in India are as follows:

c. COMMUNITY ASSOCIATIONS

These are formed to protect and safeguard interests of certain communities. For example, Kongunadu Munnetra Kazhagam, Vishwa Hindu Parishad, Schedule Caste Federation etc.



d. PROFESSIONAL GROUPS

These represent the interests of members of particular profession. For example, All India Bar Association, Engineers Association, Medical Council, etc.



MAJOR PRESSURE GROUPS IN INDIA

Some of the major pressure groups in India are as follows:

e. TRIBAL GROUPS

These articulate the interests of the tribal population. Some of the active groups are Tribal Sang of Assam, Bodos Development Federation, United Mizo Federal Organization, etc.



f. STUDENT'S ORGANIZATION

These groups pressurize the government on various issues faced by the students such as education, fee structure, etc. some of the organizations that represent the interest of the students are, Democratic Youth Federation of India, All India Student Federation, National Students' Union of India, Akhil Bhartiya Vidyarthi Parishad etc.



MAJOR PRESSURE GROUPS IN INDIA

Some of the major pressure groups in India are as follows:

g. BUSINESS GROUPS

They are independent of the political groups and parties, but influence them in making policies and decisions, especially they play a significant role in budget formulation. Some

of the organizations are, Association Chamber of Commerce, Confederation of Indian Industries, and Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce, etc.



Confederation of Indian Industry



INTEREST GROUPS: FOR AND AGAINST

FOR

The following are the arguments made in favor of the interest groups:

- 1 They help to widen the scope of political participation, by providing an alternative path to participate in the politics without involving with any political party. They also help in nurturing of grass roots activism.
- 2 They also help to maintain the political stability by creating a channel of communication between the people and the administrators, whereby aligning the outputs with that of the inputs required.
- 3 They help in promoting, propagating debate and discussion, thus creating an informed and educated electorate. This helps in improving the quality of the public policy.
- 4 They help in strengthening of the alternate representation whose voice are generally unheard and ignored by the political parties and the government. They also provide means of influencing the policies of the government between the elections.



INTEREST GROUPS: FOR AND AGAINST

The following are the arguments made against the interest groups:

AGAINST

- 1 These groups tend to make the policy process much more secretive and closed by influencing the decisions which are in no way subject to scrutiny by the public.
- 2 They are considered to be socially and politically divisive as they represent only particular interest and not general interest of the society. They advance only minority interests against that of the entire society.
- 3 They also tend to make the societies ungovernable as they create an array of vested interest which block the legitimate functioning and decision-making of the government. They make the policies unworkable if it not aligned to their interests.
- 4 They create political inequality by voicing only the concerns of the wealthy and the privileged, those who do not have financial means, or education or other resources go unrepresented.



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